It was in this context that VOC wrote from Colombo to an unidentified addressee on 7 August.[37]

> I have just now received information saying that the Steamers start from Bombay on the 9th instant and our brother is travelling on it. The Tuticorin people have asked me to return to Tuticorin by to-day Steamer. Though I do not start to-day, I have some business here now with the Melapalayam merchants & so I am not able to go to you now. I would humbly request you will be kindly pleased to come over here at once & also to excuse me. Please inform your partner about the arrival of the Steamer.

Following this, on 6 September, VOC sailed to Colombo for chartering another steamer. The spirit was such that even though his travel plans were a secret, a crowed collected on the beach, shouted Vande Mataram and wished him success in his efforts. Speaking on the occasion, Hassanussain, (described as a secretary of the company but later listed as a director), remarked that a crowd had started collecting at 7.30 in the evening even without prior notice which spoke both for the high standing of VOC and the Swadeshi spirit of the public.[38]

It appears that the business with Shah Line Company was resumed for some months but not without difficulties. *Swadesamitran* reported that transactions were smooth during November.[39] But trouble began to brew again in December. This time it was the turn of Shah Line Company to complain. Its agent, visiting Tuticorin, demanded that the Swadeshi syndicate sign an agreement—what its terms were is not clear—within three days on pain of withdrawal of the vessels.[40] Two days later, the Swadeshi traders explained that after unilaterally withdrawing its steamers that had been sailing for two months, on 19 November, Shah Line Company had resumed services on *Shah Allum* without finalizing a written contract as the terms could not be agreed upon. They contended that the Shah Line Company was trying to impose new, and unacceptable, terms. Interestingly, the traders argued that after the lapse of the earlier agreement, presumably on 30 September, the steamers were sailing with no written agreement, and hence they were least concerned whether the Shah Line Company